responsible for the presence of the national bird in Mahendragiri and surroundings.

As for the leopards, we kept big cages around the campus, not to trap the animal, but for us to take shelter. The general instruction was, when you spot a leopard at close quarters, get into the cage, lock yourself from inside and wait till help comes or the leopard goes.

Dhawan was particular that no animal be harmed. Once a civet cat fell into a pit dug for erecting a pole. The ISRO chairman ensured that the animal was carefully pulled out and let out into its habitat. Dhawan's wife, a botanist, would go around the campus with our nature-lover scientist Thangaraj in tow. Her knowledge of taxonomy was so great, Thangaraj would tell me, that there was virtually no plant, shrub or tree that she couldn't name in the vicinity. For the years I have spent in Mahendragiri, my knowledge of botany remained limited to distinguishing a tulsi leaf from a curry leaf.

In replenishing groundwater in the Mahendragiri hills, too, ISRO played a pivotal part. When we started civil work here, water was a scarce commodity. There were a few rivulets north of the test complex site, but this patch remained fairly dry. Rainwater ran away with no structure to harvest it. Bore wells had to be drilled several hundreds of metres into the rocky mountain to hit water. And water we needed aplenty, not just for regular use, but also for storage near the test stand as a precaution against an accident.

One of the perennial risks at liquid propulsion engine test stands is the chance of fuel or oxidizer leak. The first thing to do in such an emergency is to flood the test stand with water. For this you needed huge quantities of water available, round the clock. But water availability and the storage system was so abysmal in Mahendragiri that if we had to flood and flush once, it would take one month to refill the huge storage tanks. If we were to stick to the protocol, no tests could be conducted till this water filling cycle is completed, and that meant colossal wastage of time and delay in rocket tests.